

and showcased my design prowess. And then I launched it. And the world hated it. Complaints poured in. My site's bounce rate (people who visit one page and immediately leave) skyrocketed. My conversion rate plummeted to virtually nothing. I went from 1,200 leads per day to barely 500.

The tribe had spoken. Despite my investment in that redesign, I immediately reverted back to the old version and trashed six weeks of work. My golden child was a golden failure. The world heralded a sign, I read it, and then reacted.

You see, *the world tells you which direction you should be going at all times*. Heed the signs. How do you get the world to tell you? Put your executed ideas and concepts out into the world and let it tell you. Paint the world with your brush of genius so they can tell you how right or wrong you are.

Put your executed ideas out into the box.

DEAD COLLEGE PROFESSORS ROLL OVER

The world doesn't care about ideas; it only reacts to them. This simple fact pokes a hole in one of the sturdiest institutions of business practice—business plans. Academia will be outraged at the atrocity. Be prepared for the ultimate business sacrilege: *Business plans are useless*. Yes, I said it. *Business plans are useless because they're ideas jacked-up on steroids*.

Unless you count a barbecue-stained Hooters napkin, I never had a business plan. In fact, the best business plans are ad-hoc scribbles on napkins, old Arby's bags, Baby Ruth wrappers, and voice memos on your iPhone. The problem with business plans is that they are another manifestation of potential speed. Like supercharged garage queens, they aren't any more powerful than the lawnmowers that sit next to them. *Business plans are useless until they are married to execution*.

And guess what happens then? The moment you execute, the world will tell you just what I told you: Your business plan is useless. The market (the world) will steer your business in unimaginable places that will violate everything about your business plan. If you interview any entrepreneur who has been in business longer than five years, they'll tell you that they started off with intention A and ended up at intention B. They sell product X and ultimately end up selling product Y. The world tells you where you should be going, and no, the world doesn't give two pence about your 150-page PowerPoint business plan.

Facebook started as a college-crowd social network. It morphed from a niche site into a mass-market social network that serves every generation. I started my Web site as a directory, and it transformed into a lead-generation portal. The world has the incorrigible power to corrupt business plans the moment the idea is transformed to reality.

However, this does not exempt financial analysis. A blind jump into a business without knowing the specific financial constraints that govern that business would be foolhardy. When I made the decision to create a limousine Web site over